

JesusOnline Equip

Ministry Resources Hub

Bible Study Methods

Topical & Thematic Bible Study

A free resource from JesusOnline.

Read or share online: equip.jesonline.com/channels/church/bible-study-methods/topical-bible-study

JesusOnline Equip · Ministry Resources Hub · equip.jesonline.com

Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

Topical & Thematic Bible Study

The **Topical / Thematic** Bible Study method (often just called topical study) is a straightforward way to explore what the whole Bible teaches about a specific subject or theme. Instead of studying one book, chapter, or verse at a time, you search across Scripture to gather all the relevant passages on a topic — like prayer, forgiveness, fear, marriage, God's love, attitude, or godly relationships — and see the big picture God gives.

It's especially helpful for answering real-life questions, building doctrine, or growing in areas like maturity and behavior, because it shows how Scripture consistently addresses an issue from Old Testament to New. Here's a simple breakdown of how it works.

1. Choose your topic

Pick something you're curious about, struggling with, or want to understand better (for example, “patience,” “worry,” or “friendship”). Start narrow if you're new — broad topics like “love” can get overwhelming.

2. Gather related verses

Use free tools to find passages, then collect a list (aim to be thorough, but start with 10–20 key verses if it's your first time).

- Search keywords in apps and sites like Bible Gateway, Blue Letter Bible, YouVersion, or OpenBible.info/topics.
- Look up synonyms or related words (for “forgiveness,” search “forgive,” “pardon,” “mercy”).
- Check topical resources like Nave's Topical Bible or Torrey's Topical Textbook (free on Bible Hub or StudyLight.org).

3. Read and observe each passage

Read them in context — don't just grab a verse, look at the surrounding verses.

Note:

- What does it actually say about the topic?

- Who is speaking, to whom, and in what situation?
- Any commands, promises, examples, or warnings?

4. Interpret and organize

Ask: what is the main teaching or principle here? Group similar ideas together (for example, God's forgiveness of us versus our forgiving others). Look for patterns — what does the Bible emphasize most? Let Scripture interpret itself by comparing verses.

5. Summarize the big idea

Write a clear summary: “What does the Bible as a whole teach about this topic?” Include key truths, balanced views (for example, grace and responsibility), and how it points to Jesus.

6. Apply it personally

Pray and ask: how should this change my thinking, attitudes, or actions? Make it practical (for example, “Because God commands forgiveness, I’ll choose to release resentment toward...”).

A Flexible, Powerful Tool

This method is flexible — quick for a short devotional or deep for weeks of study. It's powerful for personal growth because it lets God's Word shape your views directly.